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## The Nyoro state

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In 1954 a county chief was taken to court, at the insistence of 'the Okwiri and all the Babito', for having spoken rudely to a Mubitokati, a daughter of the late Mukama Kabarega, after a cocktail party at the palace. He was alleged to have said 'go and call your father Kabarega from Mparo (his burial place) and let him come and distribute beer here for us at the palace' (*genda oyete so Kabarega Mparo aije agabe amarwa omu kikali*). His defence was that he was only joking, but the joke, if joke it was, was perhaps in rather poor taste. Anyway, he was fined 100 shillings.

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None of these recommendations was accepted by the Rukurato, but the fact that they were made shows that Babito still regarded themselves as an aristocratic élite, claiming high ascribed status in the hierarchy of prestige. To them, and to many other traditionally minded Banyoro, there seemed nothing inappropriate in the notion that as a hereditary aristocracy they should enjoy privileges and rights not available to ordinary people.

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Bitto prestige was also marked in other ways. Babito who could establish a clear genealogical connection with the royal line had a right to claim from the Mukama a special brass ankle-ring (*kikomo*). They expected to receive deference and respect from commoners, and they generally did. Babito's right

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to exercise authority was not questioned, even though *qua*Babito, they no longer held political power. However, many  100 Babito still held large private estates (*bibanja*), and in the 1950s the attitude of these Babito proprietors to the peasants settled on their estates was often said to be particularly autocratic, as compared with that of non-Babito landowners. Babito were often said to be arrogant, demanding, and indifferent to the rights of others. In fact many were not so, but in the 1950s some undoubtedly were. In the largest of the village surveys which I carried out in Bunyoro, the only household out of over a hundred which actively resented my inquiries and completely refused to co-operate was a Bito one. Sometimes Bito arrogance was resented, but more often it was not. 'The Babito were chosen long ago to rule us,' an old peasant informant told me, 'if it were not for them there would be no royal line to govern, and to be governed by Bairu would be intolerable.' Thus the mythical charter for Bito pre-eminence was still valid in the 1950s, and I should not be surprised if, for some, it still is. So, like aristocracies elsewhere which have survived the social conditions in which they played an effective political role, the Babito clung to the outward signs of their lost authority, and lorded it over a peasant population which still showed few signs of resentment. It might have been supposed that Babito, anxious for the reality of power, would have sought positions in the modern hierarchy of official chiefs. In fact, relatively few had done so; Babito were hardly better represented in proportion to their numbers than were several other clans.<sup>1</sup> This is quite consistent with traditional Bito values. An elderly Mubito well expressed their attitude: 'we are Babito; how could we allow ourselves to be employed as subordinates to senior chiefs who would probably be Bairu?' Like most traditional Nyoro values, ideas about the Babito, and Babito's ideas about themselves, were changing rapidly. But in the 1950s many still clung to the older standards.

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<sup>1</sup> In 1955 one out of the four county chiefs was a Mubito (like the reigning king he was a son of the former Mukama Kabarega); four out of twenty-five sub-county chiefs, and two out of sixty-five 'parish' chiefs (*miruka*) were Babito.

Human Relations Area Files

755 Prospect Street  
New Haven, CT 06511

General Inquiries:  [hraf@yale.edu](mailto:hraf@yale.edu)

Issues and Bugs:  [hraf-support@yale.edu](mailto:hraf-support@yale.edu)



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